

Weaver credits his players for flag chase

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Earl Weaver once won a pennant by 19 games and no one was impressed. There were names like Frank and Brooks Robinson, Boog Powell, Jim Palmer and Dave McNally. This season, you cannot even tell the Orioles *with* a scorecard. Oriole manager Weaver orchestrates his lineup like the greatest of maestros as his Birds fight for the American League East title in a race that was supposedly going to be over midway through the opening day's National Anthem.

"Am I a genius? I haven't done anything. Those guys out there are doing it. I can put in a pinch-hitter. I can change pitchers, and I can make out the lineup. But that doesn't mean anything unless they're doing it," Weaver says. "You can't let an enemy bat scare you, and you can't always go for the advantage of the right-handed or left-handed pitcher. There are times you have to walk a guy to pitch to a

guy just as tough. You go for the best percentage.

"These guys have just as much talent as those others"—who helped Weaver capture five American League championships since 1968. "Maybe you don't know it because their names didn't appear in the papers as often," Weaver says. "You start with the Cy Young Award winner [Palmer] and the guy who won the r.b.i. title [Lee May] and the best fielding shortstop [Mark Belanger] in the league, and every team in the league wanted to talk to us about Eddie Murray."

"They talk about younger guys, but they forget I've been managing younger guys since I've been here. The Orioles have just about supplied the big leagues with people. We've kept young guys moving while we've been winning and I've never been against giving a kid a chance," Weaver says. "Sure, things are becoming emotional now. It's that time of year. My heart is in my throat every inning of every game. Not a minute goes by in that dugout

that I'm not nervous."

Weaver seldom bolts out of the dugout just to jack up his team. When he does protest, head bobbing, jaw-to-jaw with the umpires, like in Thursday night's celebrated walkout in Toronto, it is because he thinks the umpire has blown a play or has been wrong in a rules interpretation. Weaver probably knows the rules as well as anybody in baseball. He does not deny that he uses profanity in an argument, but maintains he never calls an umpire a foul name.

"If one of my players keeps complaining about a bad call and yells at the umpires, I might go out for a chat to get the player's mind back on the game, but most of the time I only go out if I think the umpires are wrong and I'm right. I have never called an umpire a dirty name since 1954 when I was playing in Denver for Andy Cohen, the former New York Giant. He wised me up," Weaver says. "Since then, I've never called an umpire anything worse than a rockhead."